

Documentation Isn't Just Another Aspect of Open Source Development

Some projects live on, while some die a premature death – and the difference between the two often lies in the documentation. Meticulous, smart documentation can give your project the boost it needs. Here is why you should consider documentation a primary effort, on par with development, and the right way to go about it!



Often, developers simply assume that code is self-documented enough and doesn't need any extra documentation. This overconfidence can cost the project a lot. Insufficient or bad documentation can kill your project. Without proper documentation in place users won't be able to understand the purpose as well as the proper workflow of the project. That could lead to some apprehensions about adopting your open source product.

Work on it, right from day one

Documentation should never be a secondary effort; it should be a primary task on par with code development and management. Documentation acts as the definitive source of truth with the wide redistribution of content in the form of

community threads, stack overflows, and quora answers. It should fulfil the need of contributors who would like to refer to the actual resource, and provide the necessary references to support engineers. It should also communicate essential plans with the stakeholders. A good documentation ensures continuous improvement and development of a product.

When releasing a software product, we must not only ship the code but good documentation as well. This brings us to one of the most important concepts that most open source projects with well-maintained documentation follow – 'documentation as code'.

Documentation as code

Today documentation is not being stored in Microsoft Word or PDF

files. The new need is version control documentation, wherein all the docs are added over a version control system and released continuously. This concept was popularised by 'Read the Docs' and has now become an essential part of the content strategy for most documentation teams.

Tools like Bugzilla and GitHub Issues can be used to track the documentation work that is pending, and take feedback from maintainers and users to validate the release of the documents. External reviews can be used to validate the documentation piece, and to continuously publish it. This ensures that not only code, but the documentation as well, is continuously improved and released quickly.